

RECOGNIZING THE NEGATIVE CONSEQUENCES OF IMPULSIVE BEHAVIOR

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Identify impulsive behavior as distinct from more reasoned, thoughtful behavior.
2. Understand that impulsive behavior has costly negative consequences for yourself and others.
3. Review own behavior and see the impulsive actions and their negative consequences.
4. Think of more reasonable alternative replacement behaviors for those impulsive actions.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Attention-Deficit Disorder (ADD)—Adult
- Borderline Personality
- Chemical Dependence
- Chemical Dependence—Relapse
- Impulse Control Disorder

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Impulsive behaviors are much more easily recognized by others than by the clients with impulse control problems. They think their behavior is normal and typical. You must try to sensitize them to their pattern of acting before thinking of the consequences. Review this homework with clients slowly, allowing time to process each scene they have described. They will want to quickly dismiss each item and move on to the next. That impulsive action is just the problem you are focusing on.

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This exercise is meant to help you think before you act so that you end up with better results. Read the two behavior descriptions for each number and then circle the number of the one that shows a lack of proper control.

Which One Is Impulsive?

- | | |
|--|--|
| 1. Buying the first CD that you think you might like.
_____ | 1. Looking at all the CDs before selecting the best one.
_____ |
| 2. Sitting quietly in a group situation, listening to the person who is speaking.
_____ | 2. Blurting out some thought that occurs to you and interrupting the group process.
_____ |
| 3. Waiting your turn patiently at McDonalds.
_____ | 3. Complaining loudly about waiting in line and trying to get ahead of others.
_____ |
| 4. Grabbing the first piece of clothing to wear in the morning.
_____ | 4. Selecting clothes that match and fit the situation.
_____ |
| 5. Blurting out what you think is an answer to a question.
_____ | 5. Thinking for a second or two before speaking.
_____ |
| 6. Keeping some money for savings.
_____ | 6. Spending any and all money as soon as you have it.
_____ |

7. Waiting for a friend to stop talking before speaking.	7. Butting into a conversation between two friends, interrupting them.
_____	_____
8. Jumping to a new task before another task is finished.	8. Complete one task before starting another.
_____	_____
9. Start watching one TV program and then switch to another and another before any are over.	9. Watch a TV program until it is completed, then choose another.
_____	_____
10. When given direction by a coworker or supervisor, get angry and yell back at him/her.	10. When given direction by a coworker or supervisor, accept the comment and comply.
_____	_____

Now return to each of the preceding 10 behaviors and below write out what you think the *bad consequence* or result of the behavior of acting without first thinking about the consequences is for each one. (We did the first one for you.)

Impulsive Behavior Leads to Bad Consequences

1. You end up with several CDs that you really did not want after you hear others that you like better.
2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

7. _____

8.

9.

10.

Pick 4 out of the 10 behaviors described previously and write out a *similar scene from your own life* when *you* have been impulsive. Use names and places with which you are familiar.

My Impulsive Behaviors

1.

2.

3.

4.

Now describe the *bad results of your four impulsive actions*.

My Bad Consequences

1.

2.

3.

4.

Finally, look at your four impulsive actions and write out a more *calm, reasonable, considerate, polite, thoughtful way that you could have acted* that would have brought better results.

Good Behavior Choices

- 1.

- 2.

- 3.

- 4.
